NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6 3
♥ 9 7
♦ Q 8 4
♣ A K Q 6 2

♠ K 9 7 4
♥ J 10 4 3
♦ J 7 6
♣ 10 8



♠ Q J 10 5 2
♥ Q
♦ A 9 5 2
♣ 9 5 3

♠ 8
♥ A K 8 6 5 2
♦ K 10 3
♣ J 7 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠Q

Who knows whether you should use a transfer or just bid 4♥ yourself. Assume you decide on the transfer and bid 2♦. Partner bids 2♥ (of course).

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Naturally you go ahead and bid 4♥, the final contract.

The contract would be 4♥ played by South.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q and West follows with the ♠9.

You win the first trick with the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The loser count is very confused, but that ♣ suit is not confused at all. You want to be able to run the ♣s so your plan is to play the ♥ A K, and if both defenders follow go ahead and knock out the last ♥ so they can't ruff your ♣ tricks.

Unfortunately when you play ♥ A K, East plays the ♥Q, then discards a ♠.

You may think you should change your plan but you should go right ahead with it. West has two master trumps, but dummy still has 4 small ones. So play a ♥ to force out West's ♥10. He will no doubt play another ♠ and force dummy to ruff. No problem, knock out West's final ♥ and dummy will still have one tiny trump left. When you get back in you can run the ♣s unimpeded.

Usually it is good technique to leave master trump(s) undrawn.

The exception is when you have a long suit you wish to run and you can't stand to have the running stopped by a ruff.

This Deal is unusual in that there are two master trumps, but the principle is the same.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q J 9 5 3
♥ K 4 3
♦ K 8 2
♣ 10 4

♠ 8 2
♥ Q 9
♦ J 7 3
♣ J 9 8 6 3 2



♠ A 7 4
♥ A 8 5 2
♦ Q 10 9 4
♣ A K

♠ K 10 6
♥ J 10 7 6
♦ A 6 5
♣ Q 7 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♠	Pass	3♣	
All Pass			

3♣ by East
Lead: ♥J

The 2♠ bid is used as a transfer to 3♣.

If you don't use this in your system, just consider this hand; you might decide to incorporate it. So you bid 3♣ and everybody passes.

East plays 3♣. South leads the ♥J.

You play dummy's ♥Q hopefully, but North plays the ♥K.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

That is one loser too many. The ♣Q MIGHT drop . . . but she won't. There are no finesse positions. So you are going to have to establish a winner somewhere to discard dummy's small ♠.

Do you see it? The ♥8. Take the ♥A. Then play your ♣ A K. As predicted, the ♣Q doesn't fall. Then play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9. Of course South will take the ♥10, but now your ♥8 is high.

As soon as you get the lead you play the ♥8 and discard dummy's ♠2.

We know, you didn't really play the ♥Q on the first trick in the hope that South had underled the ♥K (although he certainly might have done so).

The real reason for covering was so you could establish the ♥8 by force.

Suppose you had not played the ♥Q to trick one. North would have withheld the ♥K and you'd have had to take your ♥A. Later North would have taken dummy's ♥Q with his ♥K, then played a small ♥ through your ♥8 to South's ♥ 10 7.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K J 7 3 ♥ 8 4 3 ♦ A 5 4 ♣ K 9	
♠ 9 6 4 ♥ K 6 5 2 ♦ 10 7 ♣ Q J 10 3	N W E S	♠ 2 ♥ J 10 9 ♦ J 8 6 3 ♣ 8 7 5 4 2
	♠ Q 10 8 5 ♥ A Q 7 ♦ K Q 9 2 ♣ A 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♥	Pass	3♠
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♣Q

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You could either use a transfer or you could jump to 3♠. You decide on the transfer and bid 2♥. Partner jumps to 3♠!

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The 3♠ bid is a "Super-accept", showing a maximum 1NT opener, 4 ♠s and a doubleton. In other words, partner's hand has revalued to 18 points. So you bid 6♠ (or you could ask for Aces instead).

The contract would be 6♠ played by North.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♣Q, East follows with the ♣2.

You win the first trick with the ♣A in your hand.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total =

There are two obvious possibilities for avoiding the ♥ loser. You could finesse East for the ♥K; this is a 50% chance. The ♦s could split 3-3; this is a 36% chance.

In fact, your chances are better than either of those percentages because you can try the ♦s first, and if they **DON'T** split you can then try the ♥ finesse.

Pull trumps; West shows up with 3 trumps. Play the ♦K, then a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. On this trick West follows with the ♦10.

Your contract just became a sure thing! Play the ♣K to strip both your hands of ♣s. Lead dummy's last ♦, and when East plays low, finesse the ♦9. If the finesse wins, discard a ♥ from dummy on your good ♦. But if the finesse loses to West's ♦J, he will be endplayed and have to lead a ♥ into your ♥ A Q or give you a ruff/sluff with a ♣. And on top of that your fourth ♦ will be good.

In this actual Deal your ♦ finesse worked which gave you 4 ♦ tricks.

But imagine that the ♦J is transposed to the West hand. He wins that ♦ trick but must give you the contract with his return.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 9 2 ♥ K Q J 9 7 5 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ 6	
♠ A K 6 ♥ A 10 3 ♦ A 8 2 ♣ 10 9 7 4	N W E S	♠ 8 7 3 ♥ 6 2 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ A K Q 5 3
	♠ J 10 5 4 ♥ 8 4 ♦ J 10 9 6 ♣ J 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	2♥	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥K

Partner's jump to 3NT is a lebensohl method.

He is describing a hand with which he would have bid 3NT if there had been no overcall. But he is warning you that he **DOES NOT HAVE** a ♥ stopper!

Since you **DO** have a ♥ stopper you decide to pass and play 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥K.

You hold up your ♥A until the third round.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 7

You need two more winners. Barring a 4-0 ♣ split your two extra winners will be the ♣5 and ♣3.

So after winning the ♥A, you play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit.

UhOh. Surely you didn't play your ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q???

If you did then just look at the situation now. If the ♣J doesn't fall on the next trick the suit will be blocked. Now go back in time and play the ♣10 to dummy's ♣Q.

That's better. Now under the ♣ A K you can unblock the ♣ 9 7, which will leave you with the ♣4 to slip under dummy's ♣5.

Watch those spot cards. You may have to unblock them to stay in the hand you want to be in.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 4 2 ♥ A 6 ♦ A J 8 4 3 ♣ Q 7 2	
♠ 6 ♥ Q 9 8 5 3 2 ♦ Q 10 ♣ A J 6 3		♠ 10 8 7 ♥ 10 4 ♦ K 9 7 5 ♣ K 10 9 5
	♠ K Q J 9 5 3 ♥ K J 7 ♦ 6 2 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♣10

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You are nowhere near strong enough to be thinking of slam so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣10. West wins the ♣A. They continue ♣s and you ruff the third one in dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

Those losers are based on dummy's hand, not yours. You can figure them either way but it is usually easier to determine losers based on the long-trump hand. It's important to remember it in this Deal because the zero losers in ♥s assumes you will ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Pull one round of trumps with dummy's ♠K. Both defenders follow suit. Play the ♥A, then ♥6 to dummy's ♥K. On this trick East follows with the ♥10.

The Plan is still the same, you will ruff the ♥ in your hand, but you better be sure to ruff with your ♠A. Aha! Your precaution pays off when East shows out of ♥s, but of course he cannot over-ruff your ♠A.

A very good Bridge maxim is this:When you are ruffing, ruff with as high a trump as you can afford.

Here, with only 2 trumps left out, you can afford the ♠A.